

"teaching one" and yourself).

- In your second week, you'll create an offboarding issue. by using the offboarding template.

Consider creating goals

Consider adding goals for your time as a CEO Shadow, and adding them to your onboarding issue. To make your goals more actionable, you may want to use the SMART goals framework.

Making goals will help you reflect upon your overall CEO Shadow experience more easily, and it may help you write a better video or blog post after you complete the program.

For inspiration, here is an example of a CEO Shadow who added goals to their onboarding issue.

Practice your introduction

You will get asked about yourself during the program, and it's important to describe it correctly. So stand in front of a mirror and practice 3 times. The main point is, do not say that your role is to "follow the CEO around". The program is for exploring and learning about all the parts of GitLab, and there's where the emphasis should lie. See CEO Shadow Introductions for specifics.

Coffee chat with Co-shadow

Before your scheduled rotation, try to schedule coffee chats with your co-shadow before you start the program. This gives you the opportunity to get to know them and help set expectations for the rotation.

Coffee Chat with CEO Shadow Alumni

Feel free to schedule a coffee chat with any of the CEO Shadow Alumni. You can review the list of CEO Shadow Alumni below. These chats can be helpful when deciding whether to apply to participate or if you're unable to participate but want to hear about the experience and what alumni have learned while shadowing.

Coffee Chat with the CLO

This session is designed to answer any questions you may have about your learnings or observations during your time in the CEO Shadow Program. Should it be useful or complementary to your time as a CEO Shadow, our Chief Legal Officer (CLO) hosts Monthly Shadow Chats.

Please @ mention the CLO's Sr. EBA in ceo-shadow should you wish to be added to an upcoming session, or if you would like to schedule a 1:1 coffee chat with the CLO. This option is available to all shadows: past, present, and future.

Explore the CEO Shadow project

CEO Shadows use the ceo-shadow tasks project to track issues and coordinate the requests that result from the CEO's meetings. It is linked in the CEO Shadow channel description on Slack. Check out the ongoing CEO Shadow tasks on the To Do issue board.

Review the CEO's calendar

Review the CEO's calendar to get an idea of what your upcoming weeks will be like.

Review the CEO Handbook

The CEO has a section in the handbook that details processes and workflows specific to him as well as his background, communication style, strengths, and flaws. Take time to invest in your relationship with him upfront by reviewing this part of the handbook.

Review acronyms

If you're not familiar with some of the business acronyms, take a bit of time to review them. The Product Performance Indicators handbook page has some useful acronyms as well as concepts you're likely to come across.

- KPI (Key Performance Indicator)
- OKRs (Objectives and Key Results)
- Product performance indicators such as CMAU (Combined Monthly Active User) (Internal link) and SpU (Stages per User) (Internal link)
- Revenue definitions (Internal link) such as ARR (Annual Recurring Revenue) (Internal link)
- Other business terminology may come up. Wall Street Oasis Finance Dictionary is a handy guide.

Note: This list is not meant to be exhaustive and should not become a glossary. While we strive to be handbook first, you may find that we are using acronyms without a clear handbook definition. If you can't find it in the handbook or find a standard definition on Google, ask someone what the acronym means. Not being able to find it could be a sign that we need to do a better job with documentation.

Look for values being lived out

Even in meetings where you are unfamiliar with the subject matter, there is opportunity to learn, document, and shape the evolution of GitLab's values. Re-read GitLab's values prior to your CEO Shadow rotation, and be mindful of new and inventive ways that CREDIT is lived out during the meetings you attend. You can make a merge request to propose new operating principles, which substantiate top-level values.

Remote shadow rotations

The shadows will participate in all meetings from their usual work environment.

Remote shadows get an immersive experience through the program. A remote rotation may also be an ideal opportunity for a team member who has been unable to travel for an in-person rotation in the past.

For insights on maximizing a remote CEO Shadow rotation, view takeaway recap videos from Betsy (Talent Brand Manager) and Darren (Head of Remote), as well as Darren's blog.

Tips for remote shadows

1. If you're based in a different time zone to the CEO, consider moving your working days in small increments (30 -60 minutes) towards CEO's working hours 1-2 weeks prior to the start of your rotation. This will help you be refreshed on the first day and alert for the tasks that will be assigned to you during the program.
1. Be sure that you have an ergonomic workspace. You'll be taking lots of notes during meetings, and will want a comfortable setup.
1. Communicate clearly with your co-shadow about shared tasks since you will not be working together in person.
1. Consider alternating who leads note-taking from one meeting to the next, which reduces confusion on who writes first and who follows from one event to the next.
1. Take breaks from your desk when there is a break in the CEO's schedule. It's important to take time to move around.
1. Depending on your time zone, working in Pacific Time may be an adjustment to your typical working hours. Plan ahead, especially if you're balancing responsibilities with family, pets, roommates, etc.
1. Consider switching locations in your home or workspace during the CEO's 1:1 meetings. Since you won't be taking active notes in these calls, this is a good opportunity to change position or scenery intermittently throughout the day.
1. Particularly in a remote CEO Shadow rotation, life is more available to sidetrack you. It is OK if you need to drop from a meeting to handle tasks at home, from childcare to answering the door, or anything in between. GitLab puts family and friends first, work second. If feasible, communicate these instances with your co-shadow, so they can assist with ongoing note-taking/tasks.
1. Consider taking one or two days off after your rotation. Being a CEO Shadow can be intense. Be aware of symptoms of burnout.

What to expect during the program

Documentation focus

An ongoing shadow program with a fast rotation is much more time consuming for the CEO than a temporary program or a rotation of a year or longer. That's why most organizations choose to either have a shadow for a couple of days, or have someone for a year or more. We want to give as many people as possible the opportunity to be a shadow, which is why we rotate quickly. To make this happen without having to invest a lot of time with training, we need great documentation around the program. A quick turnaround on documentation is crucial, and the documentation will have a level of detail that may not be necessary in other parts of the company.

Meeting responsibilities

Meetings come in many different formats. Your responsibilities may change slightly based on the kind of meeting.

Your primary responsibilities are taking notes and keeping time. Followed by positivity scoring.

See the other sections below for general responsibilities, such as promoting communication best

practices, recognizing CEO flaws, and sharing thanks.

See the meetings & events section for more information on meetings, such as the types of meetings and how to introduce yourself.

When to take notes and keep time

Here is the breakdown on when to take notes and do timekeeping:

Meeting type	Notes?	Timekeeping?
-----	-----	-----
1-1	No notes unless requested	No timekeeping unless requested
GitLab Board meetings (such as Audit Committee, Compensation)	No notes	Timekeeping in chat
1-1 meetings with a GitLab Board Member	No notes	Timekeeping
Legal meetings outside of Key Reviews/etc. (see doc for details)	No notes	Timekeeping
Valley Meetings	No notes	Timekeeping
E-group weekly	Notes in conjunction with EBA	Timekeeping
Customer Meeting	Yes, please use the externally-shared collaboration doc	Timekeeping
Earnings Callbacks (Video/Audio Off)	Notes	No Timekeeping
Internal meeting (CEO not host)	Notes optional	Timekeeping
Anything else (unless specified)	Notes	Timekeeping

Assume that you are taking notes in a Google Doc affixed to the meeting invite unless it is explicitly stated not to take notes.

If you're unsure whether or not to take notes, default to take them, ask the CEO before the meeting begins, or ping the EBAs and Chief of Staff to the CEO on Slack in ceo-shadow or ceo-shadow-private (depending on the sensitivity of the meeting).

Taking notes

{{< youtube "DtRWvlzOnP4" >}}

The goal of the notes is to collect the main points and outcomes, not a full transcript of the conversation. As you are taking notes, be mindful that the goal of the program is to absorb what is being said in the meetings you are in.

In many instances, when shadows are taking notes during meetings, the discussion is moving too quickly to fully or accurately capture all of the discussion points. Additionally, the shadows may not be fully aware of the full context of the discussion or familiar with certain terminology being used in the meeting. The meeting notes are also not reviewed nor approved by the meeting attendees. Accordingly, meeting notes should not be the SSOT for any meeting as they may not fully or accurately capture the discussion that was had at the meeting.

CEO Shadows are required to read these additional note-taking guidelines. If a notes document is not already linked, see the templates available [here](#).

CEO Shadows are not always the DRI for notes and everyone can contribute to taking notes when in a meeting.

Tips:

1. It's helpful if shadow one takes notes as the first speaker is talking, then shadow two starts when the next speaker continues the conversation. Shadow one can pick up note taking again when the next speaker contributes. By alternating this way, the shadows are better able to keep up with all the participants in the conversation.
1. Add extra blank lines after a bulleted or numbered line to make it easier for multiple notetakers to type notes. In the agenda provided, press enter to add a numbered line, followed by a space and press enter again to create a blank line (as Google documents will not allow a numbered line to be empty).
1. Consider clicking somewhere in the document where people are not actively reading or writing so that your name next to the cursor doesn't hide that text.
1. Showing up one to two minutes early to a meeting may give you an opportunity to network with GitLab team members who you do not know.
1. Put Zoom in "gallery mode" so you can see all participants (rather than only the person currently speaking). When everyone uses this mode, it allows everyone to see the entire audience, which creates a more inclusive environment and fosters better communication.
1. If you aren't sure where meeting attendees are in a Google document, click on their face or initials in the upper-right side of the window. Doing this will cause your cursor to jump to wherever their cursor is in the document.
1. It can be challenging to coordinate with the other shadow on who is taking notes at any point in time. Consider agreeing with the other shadow to "show your hands" in Zoom to indicate that you are not currently taking notes.
1. Sometimes people will provide some color or context before providing the main point. Consider listening to the first sentence before documenting to ensure you are capturing main points instead of what they are saying verbatim.
1. Observe how others take notes as a guide to the level of detail and summarization. Consider reviewing the agenda formatting recommendations (not only applicable for 1:1s)

Keeping time

Shadows are responsible for being aware of the current time and providing timekeeping in many types of meetings. This allows participants to comfortably wrap up the meeting.

Tips for timekeeping:

- Decide who. Past shadows have found it helpful for the individual in the second week of the program to commit to keeping time when applicable.
- Understand meeting length. Use the calendar invite as an indication of how long the meeting should last. Remember, we do speedy meetings.
- Shadows should provide a 5-minute and a 1-minute notification. You can write "Time check, 5 minutes" on Zoom chat.
- If a meeting is running over the allocated time, unmute and verbally say "we're in overtime". Don't wait for a break in the conversation.

Tools to help.

You can use this shell script (MacOS only) to run a timer for the desired number of minutes. The script will notify you 5 minutes before the end of the meeting, and will copy "We have five minutes left" to you clipboard, so you can paste the text directly in the Zoom chat in addition to verbalizing it. At the end of the meeting, the same will occur with "We are at time".

To use the script:

1. Download the set alarm script, making sure to preserve the .sh extension. (recommended within your Home folder for easy access)
1. Load MacOS Terminal by running Cmd+Space and typing terminal.
1. Run source setalarm.sh to load the setalarm function into memory.
1. Then simply type setalarm 50 to set a 50-minute timer (setalarm defaults to 25 minutes if no argument is provided).

Press Ctrl+C if you need to cancel the alarm. You may keep the terminal window running indefinitely so that it is at your finger tips throughout your program duration.

For a no-code solution, previous Shadows have used free online timers/alarms like <https://vclock.com/>. Shadows may choose to keep the timer visible in a separate window, placed alongside their Zoom window. Shadows can use tools like this to set an alarm for a 5-minute notification, prompting the Shadow to send a 5-minute message to the Zoom chat and reset the alarm for the final 1-minute notification.

Promote Communication Best Practices

It's important that everyone encourages others to follow the communication guidelines, not just the CEO. As shadows, you should remind team members to:

1. Verbalize questions
1. Stop sharing their screens to encourage conversations
1. Provide full context for the benefit of new team members

In situations when someone asks others to vocalize their question, shadows are invited to take the action. It's recommended to always add your name to the notes following the request, so others know that you will take care of reading the topic.

If you see something, say something

Shadows should notify GitLab meeting participants if their name and job title are not mentioned on Zoom.

If a GitLab team member is sharing their screen before introductions have occurred, shadows should remind GitLab presenters that GitLab does not recommend sharing screens during zoom meetings and to please wait until after introductions have been completed to allow participants to see each other clearly during introductions. This is especially important during external calls when participants are meeting each other for the first time.

If you notice that someone does not have their picture set in Google when a Google document is being actively worked on, let them know how to set one so their picture will show up in the document rather than their first initial. That makes it easier for everyone to find where they

are in the document, especially when they are speaking. Let them know that this is 100% optional.

Shadows need to speak up in video calls, and speak up when the CEO's camera isn't working or when the green screen isn't working correctly because of the sun angle.

Notify CEO on use of 'I think' and other flawed behavior

When attending external meetings, notify the CEO in a private Zoom chat message when the CEO uses the phrase I think. Hedge words can have the effect of making the speaker seem uncertain or unconfident.

In internal meetings, I think can be used to signal opportunity for others to present a contrasting opinion.

Also send a private Zoom chat message when the CEO displays other flawed behavior.

Share thanks

Share thanks in the thanks Slack channel when it comes from a customer or wider community member in a meeting.

Positivity scores

Immediately following meetings, score the CEO on overall positivity score from 1 to 5. The score should focus on the CEO's presence and reactions during the meeting. The Shadows should put themselves in the shoes of team members who are in attendance. How positive and empowered would they feel after leaving the meeting? Each shadow should give a score for all meetings attended.

If your score for a meeting was below a 5, immediately following the meeting, send the CEO a Slack DM with your score and the reasoning.

If you do not report a score for a meeting, it is assumed that your score is 5.

Score definitions:

- 1: reactions were not positive, the least positive someone could respectfully be
- 2: reactions were generally not positive, could have been more positive
- 3: reactions were neutral, or neutral on the balance, being a mix of positive and not positive
- 4: reactions were mostly positive
- 5: reactions were authentically positive

When and how to speak up

The CEO shadow program is not about you being an active member of the discussion. Still, our Results for Customers value mentions to operate with a bias for action. If a question is raised during the discussion that you know the definitive answer or can look up it up in very few

seconds, you are welcome to share your insights in the chat during GitLab internal meetings only. You might be asked to vocalize your answer. Note that sharing a single bit of information when discussing a larger topic might be more disturbing than helpful.

Tasks

The value of the CEO Shadow Program comes from the broader context you'll gain, and the interesting conversations you'll witness.

Since your rotation is over a short period of time, there are no long-term tasks you can take on. However, there are many short-term administrative tasks you'll be asked to perform as a Shadow.

The CEO Shadows maintain a project called CEO Shadow Tasks. It is linked in the ceo-shadow Slack channel. Make sure to assign tasks to the person who will complete it. Once an MR has been opened, post in the ceo-shadow channel.

Here are some examples:

1. Make handbook updates (use the ceo-shadow label).

Post the MR links in the ceo Slack channel and @-reference the CEO so the CEO knows they have been completed. It is not required to create issues for these tasks. Go directly to a merge request if it is more efficient.

1. Draft a "tweet storm".

1. Solve urgent issues. For example, help solve a complaint from a customer or coordinate the response to a technical issue.

1. Go through open merge requests and work towards merging or closing any that have not been merged.

1. Iterate and complete small tasks as they come up. Clear them out immediately to allow for rapid iteration on more crucial tasks. Communicate updates on these tasks in the ceo-shadow channel.

1. Go through open issues in the CEO Shadow tasks project and work towards closing or creating a subsequent merge request to close out. Communicate updates on these tasks in the ceo-shadow channel.

1. Compile a report on a subject.

1. Write a blog post on the public company blog, a recorded reflection of your experience, or a CEO Interview on a topic of your choice. Please see information about pitching and publishing a blog post for information about the publishing process, and be sure to read previous CEO Shadows' blog posts before you start writing to ensure that your post has a new angle. Link this to the table in the Alumni section. These do not need to be approved by the CEO but they will happily review them if you'd like. The posts should however follow the parameters outlined in the additional note-taking guidelines. In the event you have any questions about what is okay to share, please reach out to the GitLab Legal team in slack at legal or the Corporate Communications team in corpcomms.

1. Provide training to the incoming CEO Shadow(s).

Handbook MRs

CEO Shadows label the handbook MRs they create with the ceo-shadow label. You may do a lot or a few handbook MRs, depending on your other tasks. You can always feel welcome to create an MR.

We even track the number of MRs that CEO Shadow participates create.

Drafting a tweet storm

A tweet storm is a series of X/Twitter posts usually made as replies in a single thread on a topic. CEO Shadows may be asked to draft the tweets in relation to a public livestreamed video recording or some other media content.

1. Create a Google Doc with a title using the format "202X-XX-XX Tweet storm for Topic".
1. At the top of the document, include the full title of the media and a link to it.
1. If more than one piece of content is covered, use headings to make it easy to jump to each one.
1. Go through each pieces, noting interesting lines and quotes.
1. Draft 2-5 tweets for a 30 minute video, and up to 10 tweets for a 1 hour video.
 1. The first tweet should hook the audience, pose a question, or state how GitLab does something different.
 1. Attribute any lines that are not spoken by the CEO.
 1. Consider looking at the CEO's social media accounts for tone and style.
 1. Each tweet can contain 280 characters, URLs are counted differently. Make sure to test each tweet with the Twitter web form to tweet.
 1. When you add URLs, use the card validator to render a preview. This can help to refine the tweet text.
 1. More message tips can be found in the Developer Advocacy on Social Media handbook.
 1. 2021-12-15 example for Chief of Staff videos (internal).
1. Once complete, change the document's Owner to the Chief of Staff to the CEO.

Tweet storm examples:

1. 2021-06-02: Server runtimes and development environments: X/Twitter thread, Source (internal)

Meetings & Events

CEO's Calendar

1. At the start of the week, review the CEO's calendar. The CEO's calendar is the single source of truth. Shadows should check the CEO's calendar for updates often. You will not be invited to each meeting. Meetings that the shadows may not attend will have a separate calendar entry on the CEO's schedule that states "No CEO Shadows". When in doubt, reach out to the CEO's EBA to confirm if you should attend or not. There will be some meetings and events the shadows do not attend. Do not feel obligated to attend every meeting · all meetings are considered optional.
1. As a reminder, you should have your title updated within your last name on zoom. During the Shadow rotation update your title to "CEO Shadow". Here is the how to update your title as part of your last name to ensure it shows up on zoom.
1. Add the CEO's calendar to your Google Calendar by clicking the + next to "Other Calendars". Then click Subscribe to Calendar, search for the CEO's name, and click enter.
1. Because candidate interviews are marked as "private" (busy) for confidentiality reasons, the EBA will invite the shadows to those events directly. As a result, you will get an email from Greenhouse asking for candidate feedback, which is not necessary.
1. Meetings with those outside of GitLab may not be on Zoom. Prior to the call, check the CEO's

calendar and load any other conferencing programs that may be needed. It may be necessary to dial in via phone for audio-conferences. If you have any problems confirming the link, reach out to the EBA in the ceo-shadow slack channel.

Types of meetings

There are three types of meetings on the CEO's calendar: GitLab meetings, Valley meetings, and personal meetings. Please note that the program's continued success depends on the participants respecting confidentiality during the program, after the program, and after they leave GitLab.

For Valley meetings and personal meetings you may be invited to, it may be helpful to know context on the attendees in advance. CEO Shadows have created a document (limited access) that they can use to provide context to future CEO Shadows on these folks. CEO Shadows may update this document while they are shadowing. This document should not contain any information that is not publicly available.

GitLab Meetings

You will attend all GitLab meetings of the CEO, including but not limited to:

1. 1-1s with reports.
1. Interviews with candidates.
1. Conversations with board members.

Like all meetings at GitLab, meetings will begin promptly, regardless of the shadows' attendance.

If in-person, you will travel with the CEO to meetings, team off-sites, and conferences outside of San Francisco per the CEO's schedule.

The Executive Business Admin to the CEO will assist you with conference registration and travel accommodations during these time frames.

The CEO's EBA will ask external people if they are comfortable with the shadows joining prior to the scheduled meeting, and will share a link to the CEO Shadow page to provide context.

Meeting agendas should be shared with ceo-shadow@gitlab.com, as Shadows will be added to this email alias prior to the rotation, and removed at the conclusion of it.

For agendas that contain sensitive information, the sensitive information should be removed and the document shared with "View only" access to restrict access to the document's history.

Not all agendas will be shared, though, and the shadows should feel empowered to ask for access if that is the case.

Sometimes, the answer will be "no" for sensitive reasons.

These meetings can have different formats:

1. Video calls.
1. In-person meetings.
1. Dinners that are business related.
1. Customer visits.
1. Conferences.

You will not attend a meeting when:

1. Someone wants to discuss a complaint and wants to stay anonymous.
1. If any participant in the meeting is uncomfortable.
1. If the CEO wants more privacy.

E-Group Weekly Meetings and E-Group Quarterly Offsites

The weekly E-group meeting and quarterly E-Group offsites are fast-paced, with a lot of back and forth discussion between team members. Remember that it is more important to capture accurate takeaways than precise notes if you can't type fast enough to keep up with the conversation.

Occasionally, other team members are invited to discuss a specific topic with E-Group. If so, a separate agenda shared with the invited team members will be included in a calendar invite adjacent to the main calendar event and agenda. In this case, shadows should take notes in the agenda for the specific topic versus the main E-Group agenda.

Media Briefings

CEO Shadows may be the point of contact for helping coordinate (not schedule) media briefings. Take initiative, for example finding a quiet space for the CEO to take the call, if it is done while traveling.

When participating in media briefings, CEO Shadows are to act as silent participants, except when directly asked a question.

Remote: To listen in when it is not a live broadcast session, please contact the Corporate Communications team by posting in the corpscomms Slack channel ahead of time to let the media contact know.

Candidate Interviews

If the candidate is comfortable with it, CEO Shadows will attend interviews performed by the CEO.

When scheduling an interview with the CEO, the EBA to the CEO will create a shared Google Doc for notes between the shadows and the CEO. The doc template can be found by searching "Notes Doc for Candidate Interviews" in Google Drive. If you have any questions, please @ mention the EBA to CEO in ceo-shadow in Slack.

This notes document is then added to the scorecard for the candidate in Greenhouse.

1. Shadows should ensure they mark comments they provide with their full name.
1. Please do not complete the automated Greenhouse report that follows the interview, entitled REMINDER: Please fill out your scorecard for [NAME]. CEO Shadows are asked to simply delete this email.

Valley Meetings

The CEO may occasionally invite you to optional meetings that may not be explicitly GitLab related, but can help provide insight into his day-to-day activities. In these meetings, it is asked that you not take notes because we don't want you to do work that isn't for GitLab.

Additionally if the agenda document is not shared with you, most likely it is because it is owned outside of the GitLab domain therefore requesting access is not advised. However, keeping time can still be very helpful, so you are encouraged to do so if you are in attendance. These meetings are optional and you can leave at any time.

Valley meetings can usually be identified in two ways:

1. The text For the CEO Shadows: this is a Valley Meeting and attendance is optional in the meeting description.
1. The organizer's email address ends in @sijbrandij.com.

Personal Meetings

Personal meetings will be marked as "busy" on the calendar. Shadows do not attend personal calls.

Earnings Mock Call Webinars

Mock Call webinars for earnings prep differ from other meetings on the CEO calendar. There is a specific panelist link for the CEO, and a participants link for shadows to use for observation. Do not join the mock call using the link in the CEO's calendar. The link to register as a participant will be shared with the shadows in ceo-shadow-private typically by the day prior. If you do not see the registration link posted, please reach out to the EBAs and Chief of Staff to the CEO on Slack.

Earnings Call

CEO Shadows should join earnings calls via the registration link open to the public. Do not join the earnings call via the CEO's calendar.

Earnings Callbacks

CEO Shadows are allowed to join earnings callbacks unless otherwise noted as no shadows. CEO Shadows should set their Zoom settings to have mute mic when joining and stop my video when joining a meeting for all callbacks prior to joining the first callback session.

Removing yourself from personal CEO documents

For certain meetings, such as Valley Meetings, a CEO Shadow may be added to an agenda document that is accessible to people outside of the GitLab organization.

At the conclusion of the call, the CEO Shadows should remove themselves from document(s) they were added to via the following steps.

1. Click the Share button atop the Google Doc
1. On the resulting pop-up, click into Advanced
1. Click the X by your name to remove yourself
1. Click Save changes
1. On the resulting Are you sure? dialog box, click Yes
1. You should see a dialog appear noting that Your access has expired

CEO Shadow introductions

+Order of introductions: At the start of meetings, CEO Shadows will introduce themselves. There is no set order for which shadow introduces themselves first. Sometimes one shadow will arrive to the meeting first, and make their introduction as the first shadow to speak. During some meetings, the CEO may decide the order for CEO Shadow introductions by mentioning one of the CEO Shadows first, usually the CEO Shadow who is completing their last week in the two week program.

It's important to set the correct tone, so please stick to the following introductions verbatim.

When attending Valley meetings please be sure to omit the portion about your GitLab title. It can cause much confusion if you mention GitLab when the CEO is acting in an individual capacity.

When attending investor meetings, please introduce yourself and hand it off to the next team member by announcing their name.

When introducing yourself in a meeting as the first shadow, say:

1. I'm NAME.
1. I normally am a/the TITLE.
1. This is my first/last week in the two-week CEO Shadow Program.
1. For all meetings: The goal of the program is to give participants an opportunity to gain perspective and learn how to think cross-functionally.

When introducing yourself in a meeting as the second shadow, say:

1. I'm NAME.
1. I normally am a/the TITLE.
1. This is my first/last week in the two-week CEO Shadow Program.

Remember, do not say that your role is to "follow the CEO around". It's about getting an overview of the functions at GitLab.

Finding meeting recordings

If the CEO records a video to the cloud in a meeting it will eventually end up being uploaded to the Google Drive folder. Finding the video will require searching based on the calendar event name and checking the "last modified" date.

Attending in-person events with the CEO

When attending events with the CEO, keep the following in mind:

1. The CEO has outlined his transport preferences.
1. When traveling to events in the Bay Area by car, the CEO will request the ride sharing service.
1. When traveling to events on foot, CEO Shadows should take responsibility for navigating to

the event.

1. After a talk or panel, be ready to help the CEO navigate the room, particularly if there is a time-sensitive obligation after the event.

The CEO often has work events that are also social events. In Silicon Valley, social and work are very intertwined. These mostly take the form of lunches or dinners. CEO Shadows are invited unless otherwise specified, but there is no expectation or obligation to join.

Email Best Practices

In order to ensure continuity across CEO Shadow participants. Always, cc ceo-shadow@gitlab.com on emails as part of the program. This ensures that even after you've left the program the response and follow-up can be tracked.

Follow activity from the CEO

Shadows are encouraged to follow the CEO's activity on various platforms to get a complete picture of his everyday activities and where he directs his attention.

In Slack

Go to the Slack search bar and type "from:@bill" and it will populate the results.

Follow a user's Slack activity to follow their everyday engagements

In GitLab

This can be seen on the CEO's GitLab activity log.

See what issues and MRs the CEO is interacting with

On X/Twitter

Check out the CEO's X/Twitter account.

Sign up for Twitter notifications (Twitter account required) to follow their everyday engagements.

Travel & Expenses

Expenses

Childcare

Childcare is provided during the active shadowing period and will be reimbursed through an expense report. You must book the childcare yourself and it is advised you reach out far in advance as childcare "drop-ins" can be limited depending on the week. Currently, GitLab doesn't

have a "Backup Care" program so you must tell the childcare it is for a "drop-in".

If you're traveling for the CEO Shadow Program, depending on your hotel accommodations, finding a nearby daycare is most convenient. Some childcare facilities will require payment at end-of-day or end-of-week using cash/check only so request an invoice/receipt for expense submission purposes.

In-person Rotation Expenses

Lodging

Lodging during the CEO Shadow Program is provided by the company. Executive Admin to the CEO books the accommodation based on availability and cost. You can express your preference (hotel or Airbnb) via email to the Executive Admin to the CEO in question. However, the final decision is made by the Executive Admin based on the distance from the CEO and costs. Executive Admin will provide the accommodation details no earlier than 1 month and no later than 2 weeks before the scheduled rotation.

Accommodation is provided only for the active shadowing period, it is not provided during the shadow program pause (cases when the CEO is unavailable).

In case you are coming from a timezone that is more than 6 hours difference with Pacific Time, it is possible to book the weekend before the first shadow work day to adjust to the new timezone.

If your CEO Shadow rotation is two consecutive weeks, it is expected you will be staying the weekend. Accommodation is provided during the weekend.

Airfare

Airfare can be booked according to our travel policy or spending company money policy.

In case your shadow rotation includes time without shadowing, it is possible to expense airfare to fly home and back within the continental USA. If you are from outside of the USA, it is also possible to expense airfare during the time without shadowing because of the possible high cost of lodging in San Francisco if you choose to stay at a different location.

Meals

Shadows are able to expense food and beverage during their rotation and should follow our spending company money policy.

Traveling with the CEO

When traveling with the CEO, keep the following in mind:

1. Book flights that will allow you to land before the CEO so there is no delay in transportation to the next event.
1. For airport pickup with the CEO, research the terminal the CEO arrives in and plan to be there to meet with the driver before the CEO.
1. Keep the EBA to the CEO and onsite EBA updated regularly and promptly on estimated arrival time in ceo-shadow Slack channel to ensure the schedule is on time.

1. If travel plans change, please update the EBA(s) in Slack immediately so cancellations to prior transportation can be made promptly to not incur fees.
1. When returning to San Francisco, if on a different airline, be sure to arrive before the CEO and communicate a meetup location if traveling back together.

Considerations for other companies starting CEO Shadow Programs

GitLab co-founder and creator of GitLab's CEO shadow program, Sid Sijbrandij, answered questions in a YouTube livestream from Sam Altman, as the two discussed considerations for implementing a CEO Shadow Program in other organizations. Key takeaways are documented below.

1. A CEO should not optimize meetings for Shadows. They are learning by being in the room, either in-person or virtual, and it's OK if the Shadow doesn't fully understand everything.
1. A well-designed CEO Shadow Program shouldn't burden a CEO; in fact, Shadows should actively make a CEO's day easier by assisting with notes and changing relevant portions of the company handbook upon request.
1. Non-obvious benefits for a CEO (and their organization) include CEO empathy and humanizing a CEO, such that team members are more comfortable contributing input to an executive. Shadow alumni are able to translate real-world examples of assuming positive intent from their time in the program to their direct reports, further fortifying company culture.
1. Ensure that CEO Shadows do not plan to do any of their usual work. Shadows should prepare their team as if they were on vacation. Attempting to shadow the CEO while also maintaining a full workload creates undue stress for the CEO Shadow.

Alumni

CEO Shadow Program alumni are welcome to join the ceo-shadow-alumni Slack channel to stay in touch after the program.

Start date	End date	Name	Title	Takeaways
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2019-03	2019-04	Erica Lindberg	Manager, Content Marketing	CEO Shadow learnings video
2019-04	2019-05	Mayank Tahir	Alliances Manager	
2019-04	2019-05	Tye Davis	Sr. Technical Marketing Manager	Without a shadow of a doubt: Inside GitLab's CEO Shadow Program
2019-05	2019-06	John Coghlan	Evangelist Program Manager	5 Things you might hear when meeting with GitLab's CEO, 2019-05-30 video update
2019-06	2019-06	Cindy Blake	Sr. Product Marketing Manager	CEO Shadow learnings video
2019-06	2019-06	Nnamdi Iregbulem	MBA Candidate at Stanford University	
2019-06	2019-06	Clinton Sprauve	PMM, Competitive Intelligence	
2019-06	2019-07	Lyle Kozloff	Support Engineering Manager	
2019-07	2019-07	Marin Jankovski	Engineering Manager, Deliver	
2019-07	2019-08	Danae Villarreal	Sales Development Representative, West	
2019-08	2019-08	Daniel Croft	Engineering Manager, Package	GitLab, CEO Shadow August 2019 week one, mind blown
2019-08	2019-08	Emilie Schario	Data Engineer, Analytics	What I learned about our CEO's job from participating in the CEO Shadow Program
2019-08	2019-08	Kenny Johnston	Director of Product, Ops	

2019-09	2019-09	Eric Brinkman	Director of Product, Dev	
2019-09	2019-10	Danielle Morrill	General Manager, Meltano	
2019-10	2019-10	Mek Stittri	Director of Quality	
2019-10	2019-11	Kyla Gradin	Mid Market Account Executive	
2019-10	2019-11	Clement Ho	Frontend Engineering Manager, Monitor:Health	
2019-11	2019-11	Brendan O'Leary	Sr. Solutions Manager	
2019-11	2019-11	Gabe Weaver	Sr. Product Manager, Plan: Project Management	
2019-11	2020-01	Chenje Katanda	Customer Success Manager	
2020-01	2020-01	Dov Hershkovich	Senior Product Manager, Monitor	
2020-01	2020-01	Keanon O'Keefe	Senior Product Manager, Plan : Portfolio Management	
2020-01	2020-01	Dylan Griffith	Staff Backend Engineer, Search	
2020-01	2020-02	Brittany Rohde	Manager, Compensation & Benefits	How the CEO Shadow Program boosted my individual productivity during the COVID-19 Crisis
2020-01	2020-02	Nadia Vatalidis	Senior Manager, People Operations	
2020-02	2020-02	Diana Stanley	Senior Support Engineer	
2020-02	2020-02	Chloe Whitestone	Customer Success Manager	
2020-02	2020-02	Sarah Waldner	Senior Product Manager - Monitor: Health	
2020-02	2020-03	Shaun McCann	Support Engineering Manager	CEO Shadow AMA with Support Engineering
2020-03	2020-03	Lien Van Den Steen	People Ops Fullstack Engineer	
2020-03	2020-03	Michael Terhar	Customer Success Manager	The HyperGrowth Calendar
2020-03	2020-04	Christen Dybenko	Sr Product Manager	
2020-04	2020-04	Scott Stern	Frontend Engineer	
2020-04	2020-04	Stella Treas	Chief of Staff to the CEO	
2020-04	2020-04	Bradley Andersen	Customer Success Manager	
2020-04	2020-04	Cassiana Gudgenov	People Operations Specialist	
2020-04-28	2020-05-08	Betsy Church	Senior Talent Brand Manager	Reflecting on the CEO Shadow Program at GitLab
2020-05-04	2020-05-15	Darren Murph	Head of Remote	GitLab CEO Shadow recap · key takeaways and lessons learned from a remote rotation, Key Takeaways and Lessons Learned video
2020-05-11	2020-05-22	Emily Kyle	Manager, Corporate Events	
2020-05-11	2020-05-22	Candace Williams	Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging Manager	
2020-05-25	2020-06-05	Sophie Pouliquen	Senior Customer Success Manager	
2020-06-01	2020-06-19	Jackie Meshell	Senior Product Manager, Release Management	Recording : Four things I learned as a CEO Shadow
2020-06-15	2020-06-26	Wayne Haber	Director Engineering, Defend	Video and Blog: What is the GitLab CEO Shadow Program? Why should you apply to participate? How did I see the GitLab values in action?
2020-06-22	2020-07-03	Jim Riley	Area Sales Manager - Public Sector	
2020-06-28	2020-07-17	Hila Qu	Director of Product, Growth	
2020-07-13	2020-07-31	David DeSanto	Director of Product, Secure & Defend	
2020-07-20	2020-08-10	Tim Rizzi	Senior Product Manager, Package	
2020-08-10	2020-08-21	Amy Brandenburg	Technology Alliances Manager	
2020-08-17	2020-08-28	Sam White	Senior Product Manager, Defend	
2020-08-24	2020-09-04	Mike Miranda	Account Executive, SMB	
2020-08-31	2020-09-11	Francis Potter	Sr. Solution Architect	
2020-09-07	2020-09-18	Shawn Winters	Acceleration SDR	
2020-09-07	2020-09-24	Chris Baus	Engineering Manager, Fulfillment	
2020-09-21	2020-10-02	Philippe Lafoucrière	Distinguished Engineer, Secure & Defend	Takeaways, Retrospective

| 2020-09-28 | 2020-10-05 | Madeline Hennessy | Area Sales Manager, SMB - US East | Takeaways & Suggestion |

| 2020-10-05 | 2020-10-23 | Michael LeBeau | Strategic Content Lead | |

| 2020-10-19 | 2020-10-30 | Edmond Chan | Sr. Solutions Architect | |

| 2020-10-26 | 2020-11-06 | David Fisher | Acceleration SDR | |

| 2020-11-06 | 2020-11-13 | Fernando Diaz | Technical Marketing Manager | 4 Things I've Learned as a CEO Shadow |

| 2020-11-09 | 2020-11-20 | Dan Parry | Mid-Market Account Executive | |

| 2020-11-16 | 2020-12-04 | Lis Vinueza | Business Systems Analyst | |

| 2020-11-30 | 2020-12-11 | Kevin Chu | Group Product Manager | |

| 2020-12-07 | 2021-01-08 | Charlie Ablett | Sr. Backend Engineer, Plan | |

| 2021-01-04 | 2021-01-15 | Tanya Pazitny | Quality Engineering Manager, Secure & Enablement |

|

| 2021-01-11 | 2021-01-22 | Michael Preuss | Director, Digital Experience | |

| 2021-01-18 | 2021-01-29 | Traci Robinson | Sr. PMM, Regulated Industries | |

| 2021-01-25 | 2021-02-05 | Parker Ennis | Sr. PMM, GitLab CI/CD | |

| 2021-02-05 | 2021-02-16 | Shane Rice | Manager, Search Marketing | CEO Shadow learning recap |

|

| 2021-02-15 | 2021-02-26 | Lauren Barker | Sr. Full Stack Engineer, Digital Experience | CEO Shadow takeaways from Barker |

| 2021-02-22 | 2021-03-12 | Jessica Reeder | All-Remote Campaign Manager | |

| 2021-03-08 | 2021-03-19 | Robert Kohnke | Marketing Strategy and Performance, Data Analyst |

|

| 2021-03-15 | 2021-03-26 | Sarah Daily | Senior Marketing Operations Manager | Interview with Sid: Non-Technical Roles to Technical Roles |

| 2021-03-22 | 2021-04-02 | Darwin Sanoy | Senior Solutions Architect, Alliances | |

| 2021-03-29 | 2021-04-09 | Anthony Ogunbowale - Thomas | Named, Account Executive EMEA | |

| 2021-04-05 | 2021-04-16 | Katie Gammon | Executive Business Administrator | |

| 2021-04-12 | 2021-04-23 | Pilar Mejia | Distribution Manager, Public Sector | 3 habits to maximize your work day: CEO Shadow insights |

| 2021-04-19 | 2021-04-30 | Joanna Shih | Quality Engineering Manager, Ops | |

| 2021-04-30 | 2021-05-07 | Jacie Bandur | Learning & Development Generalist | CEO Shadow takeaways from Jacie |

| 2021-05-03 | 2021-05-14 | Miko-aj Wawrzyniak | Backend Engineer, Product Intelligence | |

| 2021-05-10 | 2021-05-21 | James Komara | Area Sales Manager | |

| 2021-05-17 | 2021-05-28 | Joshua Lambert | Director of Product, Enablement | |

| 2021-05-24 | 2021-06-04 | Melissa Ushakov | Group Manager, Product Management - Plan | |

| 2021-06-01 | 2021-06-11 | April Malone | Sijbrandij Personal EA | |

| 2021-06-07 | 2021-06-18 | Taylor Medlin | Solutions Architect - Commercial | |

| 2021-06-14 | 2021-06-25 | Vincy Wilson | Quality Engineering Manager, Fulfillment, Growth & Sec | |

| 2021-06-21 | 2021-07-02 | Simon Liang | Principal Internal Communications Manager | |

| 2021-06-28 | 2021-07-30 | Christine Lee | Strategy and Operations Director | |

| 2021-08-02 | 2021-08-06 | Tye Davis Shadow Alumni | Manager, Technical Marketing | |

| 2021-08-02 | 2021-08-13 | Nuritzi Sanchez | Sr. Open Source Program Manager | |

| 2021-08-09 | 2021-08-20 | Neil McCarrison | Frontend Engineering Manager, Secure | 15 tips to succeed at GitLab's CEO Shadow Program |

| 2021-08-16 | 2021-08-30 | Christina Hupy | Manager, Education Programs | CEO Shadow Reflections |

| 2021-08-30 | 2021-09-10 | Sarah Bailey | Solutions Architect Manager | |

2021-09-07	2021-09-17	Kris Reynolds	Manager, Field Enablement Programs	
2021-09-13	2021-09-24	Darren Murph Shadow Alumni	Head of Remote	
2021-09-20	2021-10-01	Christen Dybenko Shadow Alumni	Sr. Product Manager	
2021-09-28 2021-10-18	2021-10-01 2021-10-22	Kyle Wiebers	Engineering Manager, Eng Productivity	
2021-10-18	2021-10-29	Omar Eduardo Fernandez	Director, Strategy and Operations	
2021-10-25 2021-11-08	2021-10-29 2021-11-12	Taurie Davis	Product Design Manager, Foundations	
2021-11-08	2021-11-19	REB - Richard E. Baum	Sr. Solutions Architect	
2021-11-15	2021-12-03	Sincheol (David) Kim	Sr. Backend Engineer	
2021-11-30	2021-12-10	Amy Qualls	Sr. Technical Writer	
2021-12-06	2021-12-17	James Heimback	Sr. Product Manager	
2021-12-13 2022-01-03	2021-12-17 2022-01-07	Cynthia Ng	Sr. Support Engineer	CEO Shadow Reflection
2022-01-10	2022-01-21	Marshall Cottrell	Strategy and Operations (Technical)	
2022-01-04	2022-01-14	Josh Zimmerman	Learning & Development Manager	What I Learned From Shadowing the CEO of GitLab
2022-01-18	2022-01-28	Cesar Saavedra	Sr. Technical Marketing Manager	Being a GitLab CEO Shadow
2022-01-24 2022-02-14	2022-01-28 2022-02-17	Darby Frey	Staff Fullstack Engineer	
2022-02-14	2022-02-25	Mark Scheuber	Sr. Strategic Account Executive	
2022-02-22	2022-03-04	Jonathan Miller	FP&A Manager, R&D	
2022-02-28	2022-03-11	Fiona O'Keeffe	Senior Reference Program Manager	
2022-03-07	2022-03-18	Byron Boots	Senior Security Assurance Engineer	
2022-03-14	2022-03-25	Miles Russell	Sr. Analytics Engineer	
2022-03-21	2022-04-01	Adam Vesey	Sr. Legal Counsel	
2022-04-11	2022-04-22	Nikki Silverberg	Sr. Marketing Operations Manager	Interview with Sid: Meeting Preparation and Efficiency
2022-04-18	2022-04-29	David Egan	Senior Data Analyst, Marketing	
2022-04-25	2022-04-29	Janis Altherr	Fullstack Engineer, Incubation Engineering	
2022-05-30	2022-06-10	Victor Brew	Pub Sec ISR	
2022-06-06	2022-07-01	Alexander Turinske	Sr. Frontend Engineer	
2022-06-27	2022-07-15	Tiffany Rea	SET - Verify::Pipeline Authoring	
2022-09-27	2022-09-30	Ellie Bertani	CEO, GitLab Foundation	
2022-10-27	2022-10-30	Ed Bao	Assoc Sales Dev Operations Manager	
2022-11-07	2022-11-18	Jacki Bauer	Product Design Manager, UX	
2022-11-14	2022-11-18	Adrienne Rimmer	Manager, Executive Communications	
2022-12-05	2022-12-09	Kurt Dusek	Alliances Solutions Architect	
2023-01-02	2023-01-06	Aaron Burgess	IBM Alliance Business Development Manager	
2023-01-16	2023-01-20	Stacy Cline	Sr Director, ESG	
2024-01-02	2024-01-05	Cynthia "Arty" Ng	Staff, Strategy & Operations	
2024-01-02	2024-01-12	Yin Yu	Director, Strategy & Operations	Why It's Worth a 6am Start - tips for timezone challenged team members
2024-01-08	2024-01-19	Javier Garcia	Frontend Engineer, Digital Experience	Shadowing the CEO of GitLab
2024-01-15	2024-01-26	Ben Venker	Sr. PM, Global Search	
2024-01-22	2024-02-02	Riley Longo	Customer Service Manager	
2024-01-29	2024-02-09	Dilan Orrino	Sr Product Manager	
2024-02-05	2024-02-14	Deepika Guliani	Frontend Engineer, Plan:Project Management	

2024-02-12	2024-02-23	Taimur Khan	Staff CSM, Industry Lead	
2024-02-20	2024-03-01	Emma Neuberger	Sr Product Analyst	
2024-02-26	2024-03-08	Viktor Nagy	Senior Product Manager, Deploy:Environments	
2024-03-04	2024-03-22	Aleesha Dawson	Senior Customer Success Manager	
2024-03-25	2024-03-29	Bartek Marnane	VP, Incubation Engineering	
2024-03-25	2024-03-29	Mek Stittri	VP of Infrastructure & Quality	
2024-03-18	2024-04-05	Miracle Banks	Full Stack Engineer	
2024-04-01	2024-04-12	Jeremy Wagner	Sr Solutions Architect	
2024-04-08	2024-04-26	Karen Kwentus	Sr Solutions Architect	
2024-04-22	2024-04-26	Kelsey Turcotte	VP, Investor Relations	
2024-04-29	2024-05-03	Ian Pedowitz	Director, Strategy and Operations, Office of the CEO	
2024-04-29	2024-05-10	Indre Kryzeviciene	Staff Marketing Campaigns Manager	
2024-05-06	2024-05-17	Karen Murphy	Chief Editorial Officer, Sijbrandij Family Office	
2024-05-13	2024-05-31	Djordje Micovic	Staff Data Analyst, Marketing Analytics	
2024-05-27	2024-06-07	Rigerta Demiri	Senior Data Engineer, Data	
2024-06-03	2024-06-14	Christopher Wang	Sr. Manager Strategy and Enablement (Sales Development)	
2024-06-10	2024-06-14	Sacha Guyon	Sr. Product Manager (Observability)	
2024-06-17	2024-06-21	Stacy Cline	Sr Director, ESG	
2024-07-15	2024-07-26	Kristine Setschin	Senior Manager Regional Marketing, EMEA	
2024-07-22	2024-08-02	Lesley Razzaghian	Backend Engineer	
2024-07-29	2024-08-09	Gary Holtz	Senior Backend Engineer	
2024-08-12	2024-08-21	Emily Plotkin	Sr Director, Legal - Employment	
2024-08-26	2024-09-06	Sam Wiskow	Senior Product Manager, Delivery & Scalability	
2024-09-02	2024-09-13	Vladimir Dzalbo	Senior Manager, Solutions Architecture, EMEA	
2024-09-09	2024-09-20	Hannah Sutor	Principal Product Manager	
2024-09-16	2024-10-04	Kyle Yetter	Senior Backend Engineer, Geo	
2024-09-30	2024-10-11	Nupur Sharma	Solutions Architect	
2024-10-21	2024-11-01	Dan Rhodes	Senior Managing Legal Counsel	
2024-10-28	2024-11-22	Naheil McAvinue	Director, Data & Analytics	

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Office of the CEO Overview

GitLab is a functionally organized company in which functions are as mutually exclusive as possible to be efficient. Without a COO or central operating department reporting into the CEO, the CEO gets leverage through an Office of the CEO (OCEO for short) led by the Chief of Staff (CoS) to the CEO. While the Chief of Staff to the CEO is not a part of GitLab's executive team, this senior person reports directly to the CEO and manages a team that supports the CEO and/or cross-functional projects of importance to GitLab.

Team Mission

Help the CEO be more effective and lead select cross-functional initiatives of importance to GitLab.

Team Composition

The Office to the CEO consists of:

1. The Chief of Staff to the CEO: the person responsible for running this group and supporting the success of the CEO.
1. Strategy and Operations team members: internal consultants and doers who support priority cross-functional projects within GitLab. Roles vary based on business needs, but these folks can be specialists (for example, focused on China or technology) or generalists.
1. EBAs to the CEO: EBAs who support the CEO and the Chief of Staff to the CEO.

When there are gaps, the Office may expand to include additional roles and responsibilities. For example, at times this Office has included our TeamOps initiative, internal communications, and handbook maintenance. As GitLab is a functionally organized company, the goal in most cases is to own an area until another function is prepared to own and support it.

Kinds of projects Strategy and Operations team members work on {what-projects-does-the-cost-work-on}

Given the cross-functional nature of the company OKRs and given these projects are important to the CEO, the Strategy and Operators team members are often involved in these initiatives.

Project Criteria

The Chief of Staff to the CEO and their team may work on projects that fit any combination of the following:

1. projects which build or improve organizational design, infrastructure, and operations
1. cross-functional projects that need ownership until a maintainer or exit criteria is identified
1. projects that are so broad that they can't live within a function but are too much work for the CEO or Chief of Staff to the CEO
1. projects that are important to the CEO

This is not an exhaustive list of the types of work the Office of the CEO might do.

Many Functional

GitLab is a functional organization, which means the people are organized by function. When a cross-functional project arises between multiple different Departments, Office of the CEO team members may be included to help with the planning and execution. In many cases, a member of the Office of the CEO will be the directly responsible individual (DRI) for the project.

Whether it's a product feature proposal, a new initiative roll-out, or questions from the board, the Office of the CEO is the group that can be trusted to get things done, get them done quickly, and get them done right.

Examples of a cross-functional project:

- Helping shepherd KPI and/or OKR progress

- Helping to launch a foreign entity
- Supporting pricing and packaging change initiatives
- Efforts to increase customer use case adoption
- Providing guidance around how to use GitLab's internal handbook

Under-resourced

Projects come up that are both important and under-resourced.

The Strategy and Operations team members within the Office of the CEO should be known for its ability to become 80% effective on any subject quickly.

They are generalists at their core and, while they bring special skills to the table, they are meant to be able to address important problems as they come up.

A member of the Office of the CEO might help source candidates for a strategic hire, fix grammatical errors in the handbook, and build a financial model all in the same day based on what is important or top of mind for the CEO at a given point.

The team helps with work that other teams may not have the bandwidth to do but is important to the organization and/or the CEO.

Examples of an under-resourced project:

- Creating materials for a keynote the CEO will deliver in a rushed timeline
- Supporting planning for a global conference
- Supporting launch of a new SKU

No clear leader

There may be projects with no clear leader for a myriad of reasons, including that we're still hiring the point person or the lead is on leave.

Because of the team's ability to come up to speed quickly, they may be tasked with something totally out of their domain with the expectation that they bring their leadership experience to the table, will do the work to make good decisions, and will lean on team members who are subject-matter experts.

For example, there has historically been no DRI for the handbook or related content sites. As it became clear that this was a GitLab priority, but no function planned to prioritize this within the coming year, the Office of the CEO stepped in to take on handbook ownership until an owner could be identified.

Examples of projects with no clear leader:

- Managing our ongoing relationship with JiHu in China
- Stepping in to fill a senior level role in another function in a temporary capacity

Broad

Some projects or initiatives are very broad and cross-functional and make sense to belong to the CEO but would be inefficient uses of the CEO's time if fully owned by the CEO.

OKRs are a prime example. OKRs need to happen and are key to the business but it is not efficient for the CEO to shepherd the process along.

The Office of the CEO is the shepherd for these sorts of projects and collaborates with all

team members at GitLab to achieve success on such initiatives.

Examples of broad projects:

- E-group offsite prep
- Board meeting prep
- OKR shepherding
- Planning activities on behalf of the CEO

Important to the CEO

The CEO will have other projects that come up that they will task the Office of the CEO with, such as following up on something or carrying on a conversation on their behalf.

Examples of tasks or initiatives that are important to the CEO:

- Handbook MRs
- Values updates
- Preparing for calls
- Special projects. These have included:
 - Operationalizing charitable donations
 - Supporting updates to GitLab's expense policy
 - Quantifying the value of transparency
 - Auditing training resources and creating an accessible source of truth
 - Calculating GitLab's carbon emissions and leading a first iteration of a carbon reduction initiative
 - Identifying the underlying reasons for why we didn't meet targets for a core GTM KPI and identifying optimizations
 - Supporting an initiative to increase customer CI adoption
 - Serving as the DRI for the SaaS free user initiative

How to Work

Many of the tasks are quick asks: handbook MRs, formatting changes, or questions to be answered.

Small asks should be handled as quickly as possible.

Other asks, such as OKR-related planning or an initiative that requires alignment with multiple stakeholders, require forethought and more appropriate timing.

Some amount of time each week needs to be spent moving these sorts of tasks forward.

As a rule, everything in the doc is a TODO for the Office of the CEO.

When tasks are DONE, they should be labeled as such.

The CEO will review and delete the item once it's been assessed as completed.

Prioritization

Since the team has limited capacity to lean into everything that it may want or be asked to, it is thoughtful about team and individual capacity. Members of the Office of the CEO will be expected to manage both directed and leadership (largely self-directed) work. You can find definitions and examples of directed and leadership work on the CoS to the CEO handbook page.

When newly initiated, self-directed, leadership work entails a significant time commitment (>20% capacity for more than a week), the work being done should be flagged to the CEO in a 1:1 or team meeting. This work should stay on the 1:1 agenda between the CoS to the CEO and the team member for the duration of the activity. If needed, activities may be reprioritized based on top demands and priorities.

More senior roles within the Office of the CEO can expect to have more leadership than directed work, but all roles should have a mix within a fiscal year.

Office of the CEO members should monitor the mix of directed and leadership work that they are doing and provide as appropriate in Office of the CEO Meetings, so the CoS to the CEO and CEO are aware of the current balance and can make adjustments, if needed.

Board Meetings

The Chief of Staff to the CEO supports Board activities as specified in the Board Meeting section of the handbook and as directed by the CEO.

In addition, the CoS to the CEO helps the CEO in preparing for the CEO's closed session. The CoS to the CEO should coordinate with the EBA to the CEO to schedule a 25 minute session with the CEO and the CoS to the CEO a week before the Board of Directors Meeting. The CoS to the CEO should prepare an agenda that includes an outline for what the CEO may want to cover. For each discussion topic, the following should be captured:

1. What are we discussing?
1. Why are we discussing it?
1. Where should we focus our feedback and suggestions?
1. Who should be thanked for their work?

Designated meeting time will be used to review and make adjustments to the proposal. The CoS to the CEO will coordinate with the EBA to the CEO to ensure that there is a "FYI" on the closed session agenda that links to the prepared material.

OKRs

The Office of the CEO runs the OKR process.
We set OKRs on a fiscal quarter basis.

There is an OKR schedule that dictates the timeline of events.
We use a handbook page for each quarter.
The CEO's Objectives every quarter map to the sequence of our strategy.
The CEO's KR's are what we're measuring for the company for that quarter.

Collaborating on Cross-Functional Initiatives

While there are rare exceptions, members of the Office of the CEO are not forever owners of initiatives. They plug in to help achieve critical milestones or fill gaps. When a member of the Office of the CEO joins an initiative, there should be agreement from key stakeholders around:

1. The level of support required
1. The Office of the CEO members' scope and responsibilities
1. The exit criteria for the Office of the CEO
1. If required, the long-term plan for ongoing initiative or project support

Office of the CEO members can be reassigned based on the needs of the business and priorities of the CEO. In most cases, a member of the Office of the CEO will remain with a project until the exit criteria for the Office of the CEO is achieved. If a project extends beyond its anticipated timeframe or priorities change, a member may have to leave a project before the agreed upon exit criteria is achieved.

When a member of the Office of the CEO exits an ongoing initiative they will:

1. Provide as much notice as possible that the Office of the CEO will no longer support the initiative
1. Document their key responsibilities
1. Support a project DRI in identifying new owners
1. When possible, stay engaged in the initiative in a limited capacity during an agreed upon transition period

There may be instances in which the Office of the CEO leaving leads to a project scope being reduced or deprioritized. In these instances, the Office of the CEO member will be responsible for engaging key stakeholders around the keep/expand scope or go/no-go decision. It will be clearly documented and key folks will be involved in the decision and aware of the outcome.

Quarterly Kickoff

The CEO does a Quarterly Kickoff in the first month of each quarter. The Office of the CEO plays a role in creating materials, recording content, and preparing the CEO. Details can be found on the All-Company Meetings page of the handbook.

E-Group Offsite

The executives get together every quarter for the e-group offsite.
The CoS to the CEO plays an important role.
It's 3 to 4 days